Two Righteousnesses

… and How God Is Known

"For ignoring the righteousness that comes from God, and seeking instead to establish their own righteousness, they did not submit to God's righteousness."
(Romans 10:3)

https://TeachTheWord.Church

Two Kinds of Righteousness

Every person lives under one or the other

The righteousness OF MAN

- Built on self-trust; depends on performance.
- Measures worth by effort, comparison, behavior.
- The righteousness of the scribes and Pharisees.
- Strong on the outside → cannot stand before God.

Says: "prove yourself."

The righteousness OF GOD

- Does not come from us → it comes from Him.
- Given by grace, received through faith, grounded in Christ.
- Begins not with what we do, but what Christ has done.
- Produces a new life that changes how we live.

Says: "trust Christ."

"Unless your righteousness goes beyond that of the experts in the law and the Pharisees, you will never enter the kingdom of heaven." **(Matthew 5:20)**
Not more rule-keeping → a different kind of righteousness altogether.

"Christ is the end of the law, with the result that there is righteousness for everyone who believes." **(Romans 10:4)**
The danger: a person can be serious, religious, and sincere → and still miss God by building his own.

How God Is Actually Known

Promised, then given → an inside work

PROMISED
Jeremiah 31:31–34

A new covenant: *"I will put my law within them… write it on their hearts."* The result: *"they will all know me."*
Not information → relationship.

BORN
John 3:3–6

"Unless a person is born from above…" "What is born of the Spirit is spirit."
The Spirit brings life to the human spirit → a new creation (2 Cor 5:17).

WITNESSED
Romans 8:2, 9–16

The Spirit sets free from sin and death, dwells inside, gives life → and *"bears witness to our spirit that we are God's children."*
Spirit-to-spirit knowing.

Knowing God is His work in you, not your climb toward Him. *"They will ALL know me" → from the least to the greatest.*

Why This Week Sits Here

The load-bearing wall of the whole course

Everything ahead of us → the covenant tests (Unit III), the living sacrifice, church order, the commission → describes **obedience.**
If we place this week wrong, the whole course is heard as: earn your standing with God.

So, hear it now, and hear it at Weeks 7, 9, and 12:

Obedience is the SHAPE of faith → not its PRICE.

The pattern is fixed in the exodus itself:

- God redeemed Israel from Egypt → by blood and grace → ***and THEN*** brought them to the wilderness to be tested (Deut 8:2).
- The tests came **after** the rescue → never to accomplish it.
- Law at Sinai followed redemption from Egypt; it did not buy it.

Same order in the New Covenant → grace first, then the life it produces:

- ***"By grace you are saved through faith, and this is not from yourselves; it is the gift of God; it is not from works… For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works."*** **(Ephesians 2:8–10)**
- **Saved for good works → not by them. Mercy first. Altar second (Rom 12)**

One Root, Two Poisons

Why self-righteousness fails you either way

PRIDE
when the scorecard reads well: *"I'm doing better than they are."*

→

DESPAIR
when it reads badly: *"I'll never be enough."*

Same root: both keep score. Both make *my performance* the measure of my standing. Pride and despair are the two readings of one scoreboard → and the gift removes the scoreboard.

The cure is not "score higher" or "stop caring." It is a different righteousness entirely:

- ***"There is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus."* (Romans 8:1)**
- **The proud man and the despairing man need the same sentence → not a better score, but Christ's.**
- *Depend on Him daily → not just at the beginning of faith, but all the way through. The same grace that saves is the grace that sustains.*

Discussion

Ten minutes → this is the week's practice

1. How do pride and despair both grow from the same root of self-righteousness? Which one is your own default?

2. What does daily dependence on given-righteousness actually look like → on an ordinary Tuesday, not just at conversion?

Berean rule stands: *every claim goes back to the text → eager, and examining.*

Read Like a Berean

For next week → eager, and examining

For next week, read:

- **Acts 17:10–12** → what exactly made the Bereans "more open-minded"? Notice both halves of what they did.
- **1 Corinthians 2:6–16** → how is spiritual truth known? Why can't it be reasoned to from the outside?

Next week: *The Berean Method → discerning the sacred and the true. A gift this valuable must be told apart from its counterfeits.*

This lesson in one sentence:

Obedience is the shape of faith, not its price. Mercy first. Altar second.

"There is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus." (Romans 8:1)

https://TeachTheWord.Church